PIERCE COUNTY HOT WORK PROCEDURE

Summary: *Hot Work is defined as any process that can be a source of ignition to flammable material or creates a fire hazard regardless of the presence of flammable material in the workplace. Common hot work processes are welding, soldering, cutting, grinding and brazing.*

SCOPE AND RESPONSIBILITY

Fire and/or explosions initiated by hot work is completely avoidable and unacceptable. As a result, hot work may only be conducted on or in Pierce County sites or facilities when:

(1) no other suitable (or safer) means can be found to produce the desired result

(2) no other safe location can be located to do the hot work; and

(3) personnel doing the hot work are trained and in compliance with the following appropriate procedures.

All Pierce County employees or contract personnel needing to conduct hot work on or in Pierce County premises must receive the necessary training and instruction to be able to accept responsibility for safe, loss-free hot work operations and must adhere to this written procedure.

No Pierce County employees or contractor personnel shall be authorized to conduct hot work without a permit signed by an authorized Pierce County Supervisor or Pierce County Permit Issuing Authority (PCPIA).

Pierce County Hot Work Permits are available at Forms | Pierce County, WA - Official Website (piercecountywa.gov) or contractors may use another PCPIA approved permit.

Compliance failures from this procedure or permit precaution requirements shall create an immediate "Stop Work" order and be brought to the attention of the presiding Piece County Supervisor or contractor representative for immediate resolution and compliance.

Failure to comply with this procedure is cause for disciplinary action for Pierce County personnel and the dismissal or replacement of any contract personnel.

HOT WORK PROCESS

1. A Pierce County Supervisor shall determine if the hot work can be avoided or substituted using an alternative method. For example, using a hack saw or pipe cutter cutting pipe as opposed to flame cutting.
2. A Pierce County Supervisor shall determine if hot work can be moved to a safer location or if it is practical and/or possible to remove all combustibles from the work area.
3. When hot work is determined to be unavoidable, a properly administered hot work permit shall be obtained and displayed in the immediate work area where the hot work is being conducted. To be considered valid a hot permit must contain:
    a. the location and nature of the hot work
    b. the name and signature of the individual doing the hot work
    c. identify if the work is being done by a county employee or contractor
    d. type of ventilation to be used
    e. identification of all required precautions
    f. an expiration date and time (not beyond one work shift)
    g. emergency notification procedures
    h. approval signature and date of the PCPIA
4. Designate and place fire watch personnel as necessary in all affected spaces prior to hot work commencement and for 60 minutes after hot work is completed.
5. Permit approver shall conduct final hot work area inspections and close out hot work permits, as conditions allow, no sooner than one hour after hot work completion.

Contractors are expected to and shall abide by the above listed process and ensure their employees are trained and understand their roles in the process.

PCPIA shall confirm the applicable hot work permit checklist precautions have been identified and are being followed before permit issue and during the job task. Copies of closed out permits shall be maintained by Pierce County for at least 12 months.

Fire watch personnel shall be trained in basic incipient fire extinguishing and are expected to maintain a constant vigil for sparks, ignition, or fire hazards, and be ready to provide initial fire response extending to floors above, and adjacent to the work zone.

After the fire watch is suspended the PCPIA may consider the hot work area be monitored up to an additional three hours via video, routine rounds, or schedule checks.

THE 35-FOOT (11-M) RULE

For isolating fuel sources from ignition sources, the following fire safety precautions listed shall be strictly enforced and applies to the surface area within 35 ft (11 m) of hot work.

1. Sweep floors clean, removing grease and oils as well. Do not simply soak them up with sawdust. Cover floors made of combustible material (e.g., plank on steel, wood block) with fire-resistant tarpaulins or other noncombustible material.
2. Remove flammable liquids like paints, oil and lacquers from the work area. Do not just seal them.
3. Protect combustibles that cannot be moved with fire-resistive tarpaulins or metal shields. This includes all storage or machinery with grease or lint deposits.
4. Either eliminate explosive atmospheres or prohibit the hot work. Halt processes that produce explosive atmospheres, and continuously monitor the area for accumulation of combustible gases before, during and after hot work.
5. Cover all wall and floor openings. Plug floor and wall penetration holes with an appropriate commercial fire stop material.
6. Seal ductwork and duct openings with metal covers built for the vents or cover them with fire-resistive tarpaulins. (Ductwork is invariably dusty and can circulate fire through a facility as easily as it circulates air. Ductwork also can have combustible coverings and/or insulation.)
7. Close all doors and fire doors to prevent sparks from escaping.

FIRE WATCH

A fire watch is a person or persons assigned to an area where hot work is occurring and has occurred for the express purpose of notifying the fire department, building occupants, or both of an emergency; preventing fire from occurring; extinguishing small fires; and protecting the public from fire or life safety dangers. They shall:

1. Read and understand this procedure in its entirety.
2. Be trained in the use of and supplied with suitable communication devices, fire blankets and barriers, suitable extinguishers, and if practical, a charged fire hose.
3. Be trained in what to look for, how to control it, and sound alarms if needed.
4. Provide fire watch during and for 60 min. after work, including any break activity.
5. Not leave the area unless properly relieved by another suitable fire watch.

CONTRACTING HOT WORK

Many hot work operations are contracted including, but not limited to cutting, welding, joint soldering, paint removal, re-roofing, etc. The tendency is to relax rigid procedures for contractors assuming they know their jobs. This is not an acceptable practice and shall not be allowed to happen.

Contractors shall be provided a copy of this procedure and informed that they must adhere to the procedures established in it for hot work operations by Pierce County and any applicable standards of the Washington Industrial Safety and Health Act. They shall also be informed that they are responsible for training their own employees and providing their own competent fire watch personnel.

Contracted personnel shall not conduct hot work without an assigned Facility employee to assist in oversight and compliance.

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References: WAC 296-155-410.